

Japanese Izakaya

Breakfast & Lunch â 7:00am to 3:00pm

Full Recipe Cards Â US Market Food Costing Â Kitchen Prep Flow Â Financial Forecast

The art of Japanese comfort food â from smoky yakitori to silky tonkotsu. Izakaya dining is convivial, share-plate culture at its finest: small dishes, cold beer, warm sake, great conversation.

38	\$40	22%	\$50,036
SEATS	AVG SPEND	FOOD COST TARGET	EST. MONTHLY NET

About This Guide: Izakaya translates loosely as "stay-and-drink-place" â but the modern izakaya is equally about the food. Japanese cuisine is built on a handful of deeply studied principles: umami layering through dashi, miso, and soy; precision temperature control; contrast of textures; and the concept of ma (é) â intentional spacing between tastes, textures, and courses. This guide covers the essential izakaya repertoire with exact US 2025 wholesale food costs, complete recipe technique cards (with the reasoning behind each step), kitchen prep flows, financial projections, and service scripts to create a genuinely profitable and memorable operation.

THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

“I could break down a tonkotsu broth blindfolded. I had been building someone else’s restaurant for fifteen years. This guide taught me to build my own.”

Kenji had worked in Japanese restaurants since he was 19. Line cook at 19, sous chef at 25, head chef at a high-volume izakaya in San Francisco’s Japantown by 31. He understood Japanese food at a cellular level — the dashi hierarchy (kombu first, katsuobushi second, never the reverse), the difference between white and red miso and when to use each, why tonkotsu broth must be at a rolling boil for the first two hours to emulsify the fat into the creamy white colour that defines the style. He knew all of it.

What he didn’t know was what any of it cost him. His boss kept the numbers. When the restaurant changed hands and the new owners brought their own team, Kenji was out. 34 years old, the best Japanese cook in his neighbourhood, no job — and a sudden, clarifying realisation: every customer who came back for his karaage, every regular who requested his yakitori, every guest who lingered over his tonkotsu — that loyalty was attached to an address that wasn’t his.

The prep flow table in this guide — the one that starts at 7am and ends at 3pm — was the document that changed everything. Not because it told him anything new about cooking. Because it translated his fifteen years of knowledge into a format that a bank could read, a business partner could understand, and a line cook with six months of experience could execute without him standing over their shoulder.

He opened a 38-seat izakaya in the Mission District. The tonkotsu broth goes on at 5pm the day before service. His sake menu has seven expressions — two warm, three cold, two sparkling. His matcha latte outsells every soft drink. Month five net: \$47,000. An izakaya is not a restaurant. It is a gathering place. This guide is how you build the gathering place — and own it.

Kenji M. · Japanese Izakaya · Mission District, San Francisco · Est. Month 5 Net: \$47,000

1 Entrées

Edamame à Salted Steamed Soybeans

Sea salt, togarashi, sesame oil finish À Sell: \$6.99

± 6 min

ð Entrée

Target FC: 14%



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Frozen edamame (in pod)	180g	\$0.40
Sea salt (cooking + finish)	4g	\$0.01
Togarashi (seven-spice blend)	1g	\$0.03
Sesame oil (finishing)	2ml	\$0.03
Total cost per serve		\$0.47

Cost per serve	\$0.47
Sell price	\$6.99
Food cost %	6.7%
Contribution margin	\$6.52

METHOD

- 1 Bring a large pot of heavily salted water to a rolling boil à salt level should taste noticeably salty, approximately 1 tablespoon per litre. This is not just seasoning the edamame; the salt actually penetrates the pod wall during cooking, seasoning the beans from the outside in. Under-salted water produces bland edamame no matter how much you finish them after.
- 2 Add frozen edamame directly to boiling water à do not thaw first. Frozen edamame dropped into boiling water experiences rapid surface blanching that sets a bright vibrant green colour before the interior has time to soften excessively. Boil exactly 4 minutes for frozen pods. Overcooking turns them grey and mushy; undercooked beans are starchy and chalky.
- 3 Drain immediately and toss while hot in a bowl with fine sea salt and togarashi. The residual heat opens the pores of the pod skin slightly, allowing the seasoning to adhere. If you season cold, it slides off. The togarashi provides subtle heat and citrus from the yuzu peel component à a step above plain salted edamame.
- 4 Finish with a single small drizzle of sesame oil à less than 2ml. This is aromatic, not a coating. Sesame oil

is potent; too much overwhelms the clean bean flavour. Serve immediately in a small wooden bowl or ceramic dish with an empty bowl beside it for the discarded pods. This two-bowl presentation signals respect for the guest's comfort.

Chef's Tip: Edamame is your highest-margin item on the menu. It should land on every table within 3 minutes of seating â offered by the server as a complimentary snack while guests settle in, or charged as part of an izakaya cover charge. Either way, it sets the tone: Japanese, warm, immediate hospitality. Never let a table sit for more than 5 minutes without something in front of them.

SOY SESAME

Agedashi Tofu â Deep-Fried Silken Tofu in Dashi Broth

Silken tofu, light katakuriko crust, dashi-soy broth, daikon, ginger Â- Sell: \$10.99

â± 10 min

â¢ EntrÃ©e

Target FC: 16%



INGREDIENTS (3 PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Silken tofu	200g	\$0.55
Katakuriko (potato starch)	25g	\$0.06
Dashi stock	180ml	\$0.15
Soy sauce	15ml	\$0.05
Mirin	10ml	\$0.04
Daikon (grated)	30g	\$0.04
Fresh ginger (grated)	5g	\$0.02
Scallion (sliced)	5g	\$0.02
Neutral oil (frying, usage)	approx.	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$1.01

Cost per serve	\$1.01
Sell price	\$10.99
Food cost %	9.2%
Contribution margin	\$9.98

METHOD

- 1 Press silken tofu gently between paper towels for 20 minutes before service prep â silken tofu holds more water than firm, and surface moisture causes violent oil spattering and prevents the starch crust from adhering. The pressing must be gentle; silken tofu breaks easily. This prep step is what separates a professional agedashi from a home attempt that collapses in the fryer.
- 2 Cut into 5cm cubes. Dust completely in katakuriko (potato starch) â not cornstarch, not flour. Potato starch creates an extremely thin, translucent, almost ethereal crust when fried correctly. It becomes slightly glossy in the broth rather than soggy, which is the signature characteristic of proper agedashi. Shake off excess starch; too thick a coating becomes gluey.
- 3 Fry in oil at **180Â°C / 356Â°F** for 2â3 minutes until the crust is set and just beginning to colour â pale golden, not deep golden. You are setting the crust, not browning the tofu. The interior must remain custardy and cool. Remove with a spider strainer and drain briefly. The crust will continue to firm up

slightly in the hot broth.

- 4 Broth (tsuyu): combine dashi, soy sauce, and mirin in a small pot; bring to a gentle simmer. This is not a heavy sauce â it should be delicate, amber, and savoury. Pour warm broth into a deep bowl (about 2cm depth), place tofu pieces gently in broth, top with a small mound of grated daikon, a dot of grated ginger, and sliced scallion. Serve immediately â the broth slowly penetrates the crust, and timing matters.

Chef's Tip: The moment agedashi tofu arrives at the table it begins its transformation â the crust softens in the broth, creating a texture halfway between crispy and silky that only lasts about 4 minutes. Train servers to deliver this dish immediately and tell guests: "Eat this one first â it's best right now." This creates urgency, demonstrates knowledge, and makes guests feel guided by someone who cares. That interaction builds loyalty.

SOY

GLUTEN-FREE (check dashi brand)

VEGAN (check dashi â some use fish)

Yakitori â Grilled Chicken Skewers (3 skewers)

Binchotan-style charcoal chicken thigh, tare glaze or shio salt Â Sell: \$12.99

â± 12 min

â€ EntrÃ©e

Target FC: 18%



INGREDIENTS (3 SKEWERS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (boneless, skinless)	150g	\$1.06
Soy sauce (tare base)	20ml	\$0.07
Mirin (tare base)	15ml	\$0.06
Sake (tare base)	10ml	\$0.11
Sugar (tare balance)	5g	\$0.01
Scallion (as skewer filler / garnish)	20g	\$0.03
Sea salt (shio option)	1g	\$0.01
Total cost (3 skewers)		\$1.35

Cost per serve	\$1.35
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	10.4%
Contribution margin	\$11.64

METHOD

- 1 Cut chicken thigh into 2.5cm chunks â never use breast for yakitori. Thigh has higher fat content which self-bastes during grilling, prevents drying, and provides the characteristic juicy chew that makes yakitori addictive. Breast dries in 90 seconds on a hot grill and is considered inappropriate by any serious yakitori cook. Thread onto thin bamboo skewers alternating with 2cm scallion pieces for negi-ma style.
- 2 Tare (ã¿ã¿-) glaze: combine soy sauce, mirin, sake, and sugar in a small saucepan. Simmer over low heat for 8â10 minutes until reduced by a third and slightly syrupy. The tare is the heart of yakitori â every yakitori-ya has their own, and many simmer the same pot for years, adding new ingredients and allowing the flavour to deepen. Your tare should be made fresh daily and kept warm. Never use bottled teriyaki sauce as a substitute.
- 3 Grill over high heat (charcoal preferred, gas acceptable) at **230Â°C / 446Â°F**. Turn every 90 seconds. At

the halfway point, brush with tare â it will caramelise immediately. Apply tare twice more before removing. Total cook time: 6â8 minutes. The goal is slight char on the edges, caramelised tare on the surface, and a moist, springy interior. Internal temp: **74Â°C / 165Â°F**.

4 Serve immediately on a long rectangular plate with a small dish of extra tare for dipping. Offer the guest a choice: tare (sweet-soy glaze) or shio (sea salt + lemon). This choice is traditional and personalises the experience. Shio-style brings out the chicken's natural flavour and is actually preferred by purists â it's a great conversation starter for servers.

Chef's Tip: Your tare improves every day you use it. Start with a fresh batch on day one, then each service, add the drippings from the grill back into the pot. Old yakitori chefs call this the "mother tare" â some have pots running for 50+ years. In your first month, it will deepen noticeably. Tell this story to guests. It creates fascination and differentiates your yakitori from the competition.

SOY GLUTEN (soy sauce) POULTRY

Gyoza â Pan-Fried Pork Dumplings (6 pieces)

Pork & cabbage filling, crispy lattice bottom, ponzu dipping sauce - Sell: \$11.99

â± 10 min â¥ EntrÃ©e Target FC: 20%



INGREDIENTS (6 PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Pork belly / shoulder (ground)	80g	\$0.40
Napa cabbage (salted & squeezed)	60g	\$0.08
Garlic (minced)	5g	\$0.02
Fresh ginger (grated)	5g	\$0.02
Sesame oil	5ml	\$0.05
Soy sauce	8ml	\$0.03
Gyoza wrappers (round)	6 sheets	\$0.18
Ponzu sauce (dipping)	30ml	\$0.10
Chili oil (drizzle)	2ml	\$0.03
Total cost (6 pieces)		\$0.91

Cost per serve	\$0.91
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	7.6%
Contribution margin	\$11.08

METHOD

1 Salt the shredded napa cabbage (1 tsp per 200g) and let stand 10 minutes, then wring out vigorously in a cloth. This step is non-negotiable: cabbage is 90% water, and that water will release during cooking, making your filling watery and preventing the crispy bottom from forming. A properly dried cabbage results in a filling that stays dense and flavourful. Combine with ground pork, garlic, ginger, sesame oil, and soy sauce. Mix in one direction only â this develops myosin proteins in the pork, creating a sticky, cohesive filling that doesn't fall apart.

2 Place 1 teaspoon filling in the centre of each wrapper. Wet the edge of the wrapper, fold in half, and

pleat 5â6 folds along one side while the other side stays smooth. The pleats are not just decorative â they create multiple layers of dough that provide structure and a thicker chew on the top edge, contrasting with the thin, crispy bottom. This is the classic Japanese crescent shape.

- 3
- Heat a flat-bottomed pan to medium-high with a thin layer of oil. Place gyoza flat-side down in a tight single layer. Fry undisturbed for 2 minutes until golden. Now: add 60ml water and immediately cover with a lid. The steam from the water cooks the filling and top of the wrapper simultaneously. This is the yaki-mushi (fry-steam) technique â the defining step of Japanese gyoza versus Chinese potstickers. The bottom crisps; the top steams soft.
- 4
- When water has evaporated (approximately 3 minutes â listen for the sizzling to intensify), remove lid and add a few drops of sesame oil to the pan. Allow to fry 60 more seconds until bottom is deeply golden and latticed. Invert the gyoza onto the plate in one smooth motion so the crispy bottom faces up. This dramatic reveal is part of the presentation. Serve with ponzu and chili oil.

Chef's Tip: The lattice (hanetsuki gyoza) is a signature technique worth highlighting on your menu. Mix 1 tsp flour into 60ml water before adding to the pan during steaming â the flour creates a connected lacy crust across all 6 pieces when inverted. It photographs beautifully and guests consistently photograph it. Free social media marketing every time it's served correctly.

GLUTEN (wrappers) SOY SESAME PORK

Karaage Chicken â Japanese Fried Chicken

Soy-ginger marinated thigh, double-fried, kewpie mayo, lemon â Sell: \$13.99

± 12 min ± Entrée Target FC: 19%



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE ~200G)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (boneless, skin-on)	200g	\$1.42
Soy sauce (marinade)	20ml	\$0.07
Sake (marinade)	15ml	\$0.16
Fresh ginger (grated, marinade)	8g	\$0.03
Garlic (grated, marinade)	4g	\$0.02
Potato starch (katakuriko)	30g	\$0.07
Kewpie mayonnaise	20g	\$0.12
Lemon wedge	1 wedge	\$0.05
Neutral frying oil (usage)	â	\$0.10
Total cost per serve		\$2.04

Cost per serve	\$2.04
Sell price	\$13.99
Food cost %	14.6%
Contribution margin	\$11.95

METHOD

- 1
- Cut chicken thigh into 4â5cm chunks, skin on. Marinate in soy sauce, sake, grated ginger, and garlic for minimum 2 hours (overnight is better). The sake is crucial: it begins to denature the chicken proteins

gently before cooking, tenderising the interior. The ginger has proteolytic enzymes that further tenderise. This double enzymatic + acid softening is what makes karaage's interior impossibly moist even after being fried twice. Never skip the marinade.

- 2
- Remove chicken from marinade; pat very lightly with a paper towel â you want to remove pooled liquid but not the marinade coating. Toss in potato starch until each piece is evenly coated. Do not use flour or a flour-starch mix for classical karaage. Potato starch creates a thinner, crispier, more delicate shell than flour. It also stays crispy longer â important for busy service.
- 3
- First fry: oil at **160Â°C / 320Â°F** for 4 minutes. Remove and rest on a rack for 3 minutes. This lower-temperature first fry cooks the interior through without burning the crust. The rest period allows residual heat to finish the centre and lets surface moisture escape. This is the professional technique â at home, people just fry once at high heat, which is why home karaage is often pale or overcooked.
- 4
- Second fry: oil at **185Â°C / 365Â°F** for 90 seconds. This high-heat flash creates the shattering, deeply golden exterior while the interior is already safely cooked from the first fry. Internal temp: **74Â°C / 165Â°F**. Drain briefly, serve immediately with kewpie mayo and lemon. Squeeze the lemon directly over karaage â the acidity cuts through the oil and brightens the whole dish.

Chef's Tip: Kewpie mayo is not a substitute for regular mayo â it's made with egg yolks only (not whole eggs), rice vinegar instead of white vinegar, and a touch of MSG. The result is richer, more umami, and tangier. It's the essential dipping companion for karaage. If you don't stock Kewpie, your karaage is missing its partner. Kewpie comes in 30g single-serve squeeze packets â perfect for portion control and presentation.

SOY

GLUTEN (soy sauce)

EGGS (mayo)

POULTRY

Takoyaki â Octopus Balls (6 pieces)

Dashi batter, octopus, bonito flakes, takoyaki sauce, kewpie - Sell: \$11.99

â± 14 min

â Entrâe

Target FC: 22%



INGREDIENTS (6 PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
All-purpose flour	50g	\$0.04
Dashi stock	180ml	\$0.15
Egg	1 - 55g	\$0.35
Soy sauce	5ml	\$0.02
Cooked octopus (diced 1.5cm)	60g	\$0.90
Scallion (sliced fine)	10g	\$0.02
Pickled ginger (beni shoga)	10g	\$0.06
Takoyaki sauce (batch/bottle)	20g	\$0.08
Kewpie mayo	15g	\$0.09
Katsuobushi (bonito flakes)	2g	\$0.08
Aonori (dried green seaweed)	1g	\$0.04
Total cost (6 pieces)		\$1.83

Cost per serve	\$1.83
Sell price	\$11.99

Food cost %	15.3%
Contribution margin	\$10.16

METHOD

- 1 Batter: whisk flour, dashi, egg, and soy sauce until smooth and fully lump-free. The batter should be very thin â thinner than pancake batter, almost the consistency of cream. The high dashi ratio is what gives takoyaki its savoury, deeply flavoured batter versus the bland wheat taste of an over-floured version. Rest batter 10 minutes before using; this relaxes gluten and produces a lighter texture.
- 2 Heat a cast-iron takoyaki pan (aebleskiver pans work for non-Japanese kitchens) over medium-high. Brush generously with oil â every cavity. Fill each cavity with batter to just overflowing. Place one piece of octopus, a pinch of scallion, and beni shoga in each. The slightly overfilled cavity is intentional: the excess batter will be folded back in during the turning process, creating the spherical shape.
- 3 The turn: after 2â3 minutes (when the edges set), use a takoyaki pick (or thin chopstick) to rotate each ball 90 degrees, tucking the overflowing batter underneath. This is the skill that takes practice. Rotate again 90 degrees after another 2 minutes. The goal is a perfect sphere with a golden, evenly coloured surface all around. Total cook time: 8â10 minutes. The interior should be liquid-centre for authentic takoyaki â not fully set throughout.
- 4 Transfer immediately to a boat-shaped plate or small tray. Drizzle generously with takoyaki sauce (thick, sweet, similar to Worcestershire), zigzag kewpie mayo, top with waving katsuobushi bonito flakes (they move in the heat â a dramatic, memorable effect), and finish with aonori. The bonito flakes "dancing" on the hot balls is one of the most photographed food moments in Japanese cuisine. Guarantee social media content.

Chef's Tip: Takoyaki requires a dedicated pan â this is a equipment investment but a strong differentiator. A live takoyaki station, visible from the dining room, is one of the best marketing tools you have. The smell, the turning technique, the dancing bonito flakes â it draws stares from every table. Consider positioning your takoyaki station where guests can watch. The performance is the brand.

- GLUTEN

EGGS

SOY

FISH (dashi, bonito)

SHELLFISH (octopus)

2 Mains

Tonkotsu Ramen â Rich Pork Bone Broth

18-hour pork bone broth, chashu pork, soft egg, nori, menma Â Sell: \$17.99

- â± 8 min service
- ð Main
- Target FC: 22%

Tonkotsu Ramen



INGREDIENTS (1 BOWL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Tonkotsu broth (batch, 18-hour)	400ml	\$0.90
Fresh ramen noodles (thin)	1 portion = 110g	\$0.45
Chashu pork belly (2 slices)	60g	\$0.30
Ajitsuke tamago (marinated egg)	1 egg	\$0.35
Menma (bamboo shoots)	20g	\$0.10
Nori (toasted)	1 sheet	\$0.15
Scallion (sliced)	10g	\$0.02
Sesame seeds + sesame oil	2g + 3ml	\$0.04

Tare (seasoning concentrate)	20ml	\$0.08
Total cost per bowl		\$2.39

Cost per serve	\$2.39
Sell price	\$17.99
Food cost %	13.3%
Contribution margin	\$15.60

METHOD

- 1 Tonkotsu broth (batch): blanch pork bones (trotters + neck bones) in boiling water 10 minutes, discard water â this removes blood and impurities that cause a grey, bitter broth. Transfer to fresh cold water, bring to a rolling boil, and maintain that vigorous boil for 18 hours. The rolling boil is the secret: it emulsifies the collagen and fat into a creamy, opaque white broth. A simmer produces a clear, lighter broth. Tonkotsu requires violence. Add water as needed. Final broth should coat a spoon.
- 2 Chashu pork belly (batch): roll pork belly tightly with butcher's twine. Sear all sides in a hot pan until golden. Transfer to a braising liquid (soy sauce, mirin, sake, sugar, ginger, garlic) and simmer covered for 2.5 hours until tender. Cool in braising liquid overnight â this is tare, double-used. The overnight rest allows the chashu to firm up for clean slicing and absorb the flavours more deeply. Slice 1cm thick per service, torch or pan-sear to order.
- 3 Ajitsuke tamago (marinated egg): soft-boil eggs exactly 6 minutes 30 seconds in boiling water, transfer immediately to ice bath. Peel and marinate in chashu braising liquid diluted 1:1 with water for minimum 4 hours. The liquid penetrates the white, creating a jammy, seasoned exterior and a soft, orange, barely-set yolk. This precision timing is what produces the prized "ramen egg" â a 7-minute egg has a fully set yolk and loses its magic entirely.
- 4 Assembly: warm serving bowl with hot water (dump before use). Add tare to bowl. Ladle 400ml hot broth, mix with tare. Cook noodles in separate pot of boiling water exactly 90 seconds (fresh noodles cook fast). Drain, shake, add to bowl. Top with 2 chashu slices, halved soft egg, menma, nori pressed against bowl edge, scallion, sesame. Finish with sesame oil. The order of toppings is a visual composition â nori upright, egg halved to show the yolk. Presentation communicates craft.

Chef's Tip: Ramen broth is your most labour-intensive prep but also your highest-margin product. One batch (20 litres from a large stockpot) serves approximately 50 bowls. The labour cost is absorbed across that volume. The key operational discipline: never run out of broth mid-service. Make batches every 2 days. Keep a minimum 24-hour buffer. Running out of tonkotsu mid-Saturday is a reputation-damaging event.

GLUTEN (noodles, soy) SOY EGGS PORK SESAME

Chicken Teriyaki Don â Teriyaki Rice Bowl

Grilled teriyaki chicken thigh over steamed rice, shredded cabbage, pickles Â Sell: \$15.99

â± 10 min â± Main Target FC: 20%



INGREDIENTS (1 BOWL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (boneless, skin-on)	180g	\$1.28
Soy sauce (teriyaki glaze)	25ml	\$0.08
Mirin (teriyaki glaze)	20ml	\$0.08

Sake (teriyaki glaze)	15ml	\$0.16
Sugar (glaze)	5g	\$0.01
Short grain rice (cooked)	200g cooked	\$0.24
Shredded cabbage	40g	\$0.05
Pickled ginger + scallion	10g + 5g	\$0.06
Sesame seeds	2g	\$0.02
Total cost per bowl		\$1.98

Cost per serve	\$1.98
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	12.4%
Contribution margin	\$14.01

METHOD

- 1
- Score the chicken thigh skin with a sharp knife in a crosshatch pattern â 3â4 cuts each direction, 3mm deep. This does two things: it allows the fat underneath the skin to render out as the chicken cooks (preventing a flabby, fatty skin), and it allows the teriyaki glaze to penetrate and caramelize into the skin surface rather than just coating the top. A scored skin produces a dramatically different result than un-scored.
- 2
- Pan-fry skin-side down in a dry pan over medium heat for 6â7 minutes. Starting in a cold or barely warm pan allows the fat to render gradually from the skin before browning begins â this is the French technique applied to Japanese cuisine. A hot pan immediately seizes the skin before fat can render, producing a chewy result. Flip and cook 3 minutes more. Internal temp: 74Â°C / 165Â°F.
- 3
- Pour teriyaki sauce (soy, mirin, sake, sugar) into the pan around the chicken â not over it. Allow to bubble and reduce, tilting the pan and spooning the sauce over the chicken repeatedly. This basting process builds up layers of caramelised glaze. The sauce should reduce to about half its original volume and become thick enough to coat a spoon before you consider the chicken done. Thin, watery teriyaki is the mark of impatience.
- 4
- Slice the chicken thigh at 45Â° angle â this exposes more surface area, makes portion look larger, and creates clean presentation edges. Fan the slices over a bed of steamed rice. Place shredded cabbage to the side (provides freshness and textural contrast to the rich glaze), a mound of pickled ginger, scallion, and sesame seeds. Drizzle remaining pan glaze over the top of the chicken slices.

Chef's Tip: Short grain rice quality is foundational to every donburi. Use Japanese-style short grain (Calrose or similar) cooked with a 1:1.1 water ratio in a rice cooker. Never use long grain for Japanese rice bowls â the stickiness of short grain is what allows the sauce and protein to bind to it. Invest in a commercial rice cooker that holds rice at serving temperature for up to 4 hours without drying out. This is one of the best equipment investments in a Japanese kitchen.

SOY GLUTEN (soy sauce) POULTRY SESAME

Beef Yakiniku â Japanese BBQ Beef Platter

Thin-sliced beef, sesame-soy yakiniku tare, garlic, shiso leaf Â Sell: \$19.99

â± 8 min ð¥© Main Target FC: 24%



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE ~200G)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Thin-sliced beef (shabu-style)	200g	\$3.97
Soy sauce (yakiniiku tare)	25ml	\$0.08
Mirin (tare)	15ml	\$0.06
Sake (tare)	10ml	\$0.11
Sesame oil (tare)	5ml	\$0.05
Garlic (tare, grated)	4g	\$0.02
Asian pear or apple (tare, grated)	15g	\$0.04
Shiso leaves (perilla)	4 leaves	\$0.06
Sesame seeds	2g	\$0.02
Short grain rice (side portion)	160g cooked	\$0.19
Total cost per serve		\$4.60

Cost per serve	\$4.60
Sell price	\$19.99
Food cost %	23.0%
Contribution margin	\$15.39

METHOD

- 1

Yakiniiku tare (batch): combine soy sauce, mirin, sake, sesame oil, grated garlic, and grated Asian pear. Bring to a gentle simmer for 5 minutes. The Asian pear serves dual purposes â it contains natural fruit enzymes (protease) that tenderise the beef even during brief marination, and it adds a subtle sweetness that balances the savoury soy. Pear enzymes begin working within 20 minutes; don't marinate longer than 2 hours or the texture becomes mushy.
- 2

For kitchen-served yakiniiku (versus tableside grill): heat a cast-iron grill plate or skillet to smoking point â **250Â°C / 482Â°F** . Thin-sliced beef cooks in 60â90 seconds total at this temperature. This high heat is non-negotiable: thin beef on a moderate heat doesn't sear, it steams in its own moisture and becomes grey and flavourless. The brief violent heat creates caramelisation on the exterior while leaving the centre rare to medium. This contrast is the pleasure of yakiniiku.
- 3

Grill beef slices in small batches â never crowd the pan. Each slice needs direct contact with the hot surface. If slices overlap or touch, they lower the pan temperature and steam each other. Cook 45 seconds per side, no more. Rest briefly off heat. The carryover heat in thin-sliced beef is significant: remove from heat while still slightly underdone at the thickest part.
- 4

Plate on a warm plate with shiso leaves as a bed (their herbaceous, anise-like flavour complements the rich beef beautifully), sesame seeds scattered over the beef, with tare in a small dipping dish. Serve rice separately. Instruct guests: wrap beef in shiso with a dip of tare â the shiso cuts the richness and adds freshness. This guided eating experience elevates the dish from simple grilled beef to a multi-sensory moment.

Chef's Tip: Source your thin-sliced beef from a Korean or Japanese grocery supplier â they stock beef pre-sliced to 1â2mm on a commercial slicer. This thickness is impossible to achieve with a home knife and is essential for the correct cook time and texture. If you're slicing in-house, partially freeze the beef (1.5 hours) before slicing with a very sharp slicer or mandoline. Never hand-cut thick slabs and call it yakiniiku.

SOY GLUTEN (soy sauce) SESAME BEEF

Saba Shioyaki â Salt-Grilled Mackerel

Whole mackerel fillet, sea salt cure, grated daikon, soy, lemon - Sell: \$18.99

â± 12 min ð Main Target FC: 20%

Saba Shioyaki



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Atlantic mackerel fillet (skin-on)	180g	\$1.20
Sea salt (curing + grilling)	6g	\$0.01
Daikon (grated, oroshi)	40g	\$0.05
Soy sauce (dipping)	10ml	\$0.03
Lemon wedge	1 wedge	\$0.05
Short grain rice (side)	160g cooked	\$0.19
Miso soup (accompaniment)	200ml	\$0.22
Total cost per serve		\$1.75

Cost per serve	\$1.75
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	10.3%
Contribution margin	\$15.24

METHOD

- 1 Salt the mackerel fillet generously (approximately 1% salt by weight) 30-45 minutes before grilling. This short cure draws out excess surface moisture via osmosis and seasons the flesh throughout. If you salt immediately before cooking, the salt sits on the surface and creates steam during cooking (fish gets wet and steamed rather than grilled). If you salt more than 2 hours before, the texture becomes too firm and the fish dries out. The 30-45 minute window is precise and important.
- 2 Pat the cured fillet dry with paper towels before grilling - removing the surface moisture drawn out by the salt is what achieves the crispy skin. Score the skin in 3 diagonal cuts (prevents curling and allows heat to penetrate evenly through the thick fillet). Brush skin-side with a tiny amount of oil - just enough to prevent sticking, not enough to fry.
- 3 Grill skin-side up first in a broiler or salamander at 220°C / 428°F for 4 minutes, then flip and grill skin-side down for 6-8 minutes until skin is blistered, golden, and completely crispy. The higher proportion of time skin-side down is deliberate: the skin needs sustained direct heat to render its fat and crisp up. A mackerel with flabby skin is a failure. The flesh should be just cooked through at the thickest point at 63°C / 145°F.
- 4 Plate the mackerel on a long rectangular plate, skin up. Mound grated daikon (oroshi daikon) beside it - the daikon provides enzymatic freshness that literally digests the fish oils as you eat it, making an oily fish feel lighter and cleaner. Soy sauce poured over daikon (not over the fish - this would destroy the crispy skin). Lemon wedge, rice, and miso soup complete the teishoku (set meal) presentation.

Chef's Tip: Mackerel is your best-value protein on the menu. High in omega-3 fatty acids and deep, rich flavour that customers increasingly seek out. Market it as "the Japanese heart-health dish" - it's completely accurate. Grated daikon is not optional garnish; it's a functional digestive aid. Tell your servers this. When a server can explain why daikon accompanies fatty fish - that's service education that guests remember.

FISH SOY GLUTEN (soy sauce)

± 10 min

ð Main

Target FC: 21%

Chicken Katsu Curry



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken breast (butterflied, 1cm)	180g	\$1.15
Panko breadcrumbs	60g	\$0.19
Egg (breeding)	1 Æ 55g	\$0.35
All-purpose flour (breeding)	20g	\$0.02
Japanese curry sauce (batch)	150ml	\$0.40
Short grain rice (cooked)	200g cooked	\$0.24
Fukujinzuke pickles	20g	\$0.08
Neutral frying oil (usage)	â	\$0.12
Total cost per serve		\$2.55

Cost per serve	\$2.55
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	15.0%
Contribution margin	\$14.44

METHOD

- 1 Japanese curry sauce (batch, 20 serves): fry diced onion in butter over medium-low for 20 minutes until deeply caramelised and amber Æ this is the flavour foundation. Add grated apple and carrot, cook 5 more minutes. Add Japanese curry roux (S&B Golden Curry or house-made), chicken or vegetable stock, soy sauce. Simmer 20 minutes. The caramelised onion is not optional Æ it's what gives Japanese curry its characteristic sweetness and depth that distinguishes it from Indian or Thai curry. Rushing this step produces a flat, one-dimensional sauce.
- 2 Butterfly chicken breast to even 1cm thickness Æ this is critical for katsu. If the breast is uneven, the thin end overcooks and dries while the thick end is still raw. Pound with a meat mallet to uniform thickness if needed. Season lightly. Bread in the classic three-stage sequence: flour Æ egg wash Æ panko. Each stage must be thorough and complete. Gaps in the panko coating will burst during frying and produce an uneven crust.
- 3 Fry in oil at **170Â°C / 338Â°F** for 4â5 minutes until the panko is deeply golden and crispy all over. Panko breadcrumbs are coarser than regular breadcrumbs and create more surface area, producing a dramatically crunchier crust. Never use fine breadcrumbs for katsu Æ the texture difference is night and day. Drain on a rack (not paper towels Æ the steam from paper towels softens the bottom of the crust). Internal temp: **74Â°C / 165Â°F**.
- 4 Slice katsu at 45Â° into 2cm strips Æ this allows guests to eat with chopsticks and reveals the cross-section of the crispy panko and juicy white chicken interior. Arrange sliced katsu over rice on a half-covered plate (curry poured on the rice side, katsu on the dry side Æ this keeps the crust crispy at the table). Place fukujinzuke pickles Æ the crimson pickled radish cuts richness and provides a visual pop of colour.

Chef's Tip: Katsu curry is your most universally loved dish Æ accessible to anyone from young children to adults with no Japanese food experience. It is deliberately positioned at the gateway end of your menu. A first-time guest who orders katsu curry and loves it will come back and order ramen or yakitori on the next visit. Think of katsu curry as your ambassador dish Æ the food that converts newcomers to

regulars.

GLUTEN (panko, flour, soy)

EGGS

POULTRY

DAIRY (butter in curry base)

Miso Glazed Salmon à Nobu-Style

White miso & mirin marinated salmon, broiled, sesame broccolini À- Sell: \$18.99

± 10 min

ð Main

Target FC: 21%

Miso Glazed Salmon



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Salmon fillet (skin-on, 6oz)	170g	\$3.57
White miso paste (shiro miso)	30g	\$0.13
Mirin (glaze)	20ml	\$0.08
Sake (glaze)	15ml	\$0.16
Sugar (glaze balance)	5g	\$0.01
Broccolini (side)	80g	\$0.32
Sesame oil + sesame seeds	3ml + 2g	\$0.04
Short grain rice (side)	160g cooked	\$0.19
Total cost per serve		\$4.50

Cost per serve	\$4.50
Sell price	\$18.99
Food cost %	23.7%
Contribution margin	\$14.49

METHOD

- 1 Miso marinade: combine white miso, mirin, sake, and sugar. Whisk until completely smooth à lumpy miso marinade burns unevenly in the broiler. White (shiro) miso is preferred over red miso for this application because its lower salt content and higher sugar content caramelises more beautifully without burning. Red miso burns before it caramelises due to its higher salt level. This is why Nobu's original recipe specifically calls for white miso.
- 2 Coat salmon evenly on all sides with miso marinade. Marinate minimum 24 hours in the refrigerator à 48 hours is ideal. The miso enzymes and sake alcohol denature and tenderise the salmon protein over time, while the sugars begin to dry on the surface creating a lacquer-like coating. A 2-hour marinade produces a pale, thin glaze. A 48-hour marinade produces a deep amber, complex, almost candy-like surface. The time investment is what creates the signature result.
- 3 Before cooking: wipe off excess miso marinade with a paper towel. This seems counterintuitive but is critical à thick excess miso will burn in the broiler before the salmon is cooked, producing a bitter char rather than a sweet caramelisation. You want a thin, even layer remaining. Place on a foil-lined tray and broil at **220Â°C / 428Â°F** for 8â10 minutes, watching closely. The glaze should be blistered and deeply golden. Internal: **57Â°C / 135Â°F** for medium (optimal).
- 4 While salmon broils, blanch broccolini in salted boiling water 2 minutes. Toss with sesame oil and sesame seeds. Plate salmon on a slightly elevated mound of rice with broccolini beside it. The caramelised miso glaze should be visibly glossy and golden on top. Finish with a few extra sesame seeds over the salmon. No sauce needed à the glaze is the sauce. The dish should arrive looking

lacquered and precious, not wet or saucy.

Chef's Tip: This is your prestige dish â the one guests order to impress someone on a date or a first visit. Price it accordingly at \$18.99. Salmon and miso are both recognisable luxury-comfort ingredients in the US market. The 48-hour marinade is your competitive advantage â any competitor can make grilled salmon; almost none will do the 2-day miso cure. This is the detail that justifies the price and creates genuine differentiation.

FISH SOY (miso) GLUTEN (check miso brand) SESAME

Gyudon â Beef & Onion Rice Bowl

Thin-sliced beef, caramelised onion, sweet-soy broth, pickled ginger, soft egg Â Sell: \$15.99

â± 8 min ð Main Target FC: 21%

Gyudon



INGREDIENTS (1 BOWL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Thin-sliced beef (chuck or rib)	150g	\$2.98
Yellow onion (sliced thin)	80g	\$0.06
Dashi stock	100ml	\$0.08
Soy sauce	20ml	\$0.07
Mirin	15ml	\$0.06
Sake	15ml	\$0.16
Sugar	5g	\$0.01
Short grain rice (cooked)	200g cooked	\$0.24
Pickled ginger (beni shoga)	15g	\$0.06
Soft-boiled egg (optional)	1 egg	\$0.35
Total cost per bowl		\$4.07

Cost per serve	\$4.07
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	25.5%
Contribution margin	\$11.92

METHOD

- Combine dashi, soy sauce, mirin, sake, and sugar in a wide shallow pan (sautÃ© pan, not saucepan â the wider surface area allows faster reduction and more even cooking). Bring to a simmer. Add sliced onion first and simmer 4â5 minutes until translucent and beginning to caramelize at edges. The onion is not just a supporting flavour â it becomes sweet and silky and is as important as the beef in gyudon. Do not rush this step.
- Add thin-sliced beef in a single layer over the onions â do not stir immediately. Let the beef sit undisturbed in the simmering broth for 60 seconds before gently folding. The gentle simmer (not boil) keeps the thin beef tender rather than tough. A hard boil causes the beef proteins to contract violently and become chewy. Gyudon broth should be at a gentle, just-visible simmer throughout cooking.
- The beef needs only 2â3 minutes total â it is thin and overcooks very quickly. Remove from heat the moment it's cooked through and no longer pink. The residual heat in the broth will continue to cook it

slightly. Season the broth â taste it. It should be sweet-savoury with depth from dashi. If flat, add a few drops of soy. If too salty, add a touch more mirin. Getting this broth balance correct is the whole skill of gyudon.

4 Mound hot rice in a deep bowl. Ladle the beef and onion mixture over the rice, including plenty of the sweet broth â the broth soaks into the rice underneath and is as important as the topping. Place pickled ginger to the side (its acidic sharpness is the essential counterpoint to the sweet beef). Halve the soft-boiled egg and place on top. The yolk should run slightly into the broth when broken â a textural and visual moment that's been capturing Japanese diners for over 100 years.

Chef's Tip: Gyudon is Japan's most democratic comfort food â a \$4 lunch for millions of Japanese workers daily at Yoshinoya chains across Asia. Yours will be substantially better than the chain version. Position it as a cultural touchstone: "This is what Tokyo businesspeople eat for lunch every day." That narrative transforms a simple rice bowl into a cultural experience worth \$15.99 at a breakfast-lunch caf  .

SOY GLUTEN (soy sauce) BEEF EGGS (optional)

Yakisoba â Stir-Fried Wheat Noodles

Pan-fried noodles, pork belly, cabbage, Worcestershire-style sauce, beni shoga   Sell: \$14.99

   8 min    Main Target FC: 18%

Yakisoba



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Yakisoba noodles (pre-cooked/ramen noodle)	150g	\$0.45
Pork belly (sliced thin)	80g	\$0.40
Napa cabbage (rough chop)	60g	\$0.06
Carrot (juliened)	30g	\$0.03
Yakisoba sauce (Worcestershire + soy + ketchup)	30ml	\$0.06
Neutral oil	10ml	\$0.03
Beni shoga (red pickled ginger)	15g	\$0.06
Aonori (dried seaweed flakes)	1g	\$0.04
Katsuobushi (bonito flakes)	2g	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$1.21

Cost per serve	\$1.21
Sell price	\$14.99
Food cost %	8.1%
Contribution margin	\$13.78

METHOD

1 Yakisoba requires high heat â a very hot wok or flat-top griddle at 240  C / 464  F. This is hotter than most home ranges can achieve, which is why restaurant yakisoba always tastes better than home versions. The Japanese concept of yakitsuke â sticking the noodles briefly to the hot surface â creates a slightly charred, nutty flavour on the noodle exterior that is impossible to replicate at lower temperatures. Preheat your cooking surface for minimum 3 minutes before starting.

   Cook pork belly first in oil, 90 seconds until beginning to caramelize and render fat slightly. Add carrot

- 2 Cook pork belly first in oil, 90 seconds until beginning to caramelize and render fat slightly. Add carrot and cabbage, stir-fry 60 seconds. Add noodles â spread them across the hot surface and do not touch for 30 seconds. This "no-touch" period allows the direct contact to create the yakitsuke char. Then toss. The combination of caramelised pork fat and slightly charred noodles creates a depth of flavour that pure stir-frying cannot achieve.
- 3 Add yakisoba sauce â a combination of Worcestershire sauce, soy sauce, and ketchup (this combination replicates the Bulldog sauce used in Japan). Add around the edges of the wok, not directly onto the noodles â the sizzle of sauce hitting the hot metal vaporises some of the liquid instantly, concentrating the flavour before it contacts the noodles. Toss vigorously to coat all noodles evenly. Total cook time from start to plate: 4â5 minutes.
- 4 Plate on a flat plate â yakisoba should not be served in a deep bowl. Mound in the centre. Top with a bright mound of beni shoga (the red pickled ginger is not optional â its sharp acidity and vivid crimson colour are the signature garnish of yakisoba), dust with aonori, and scatter bonito flakes on top. The bonito flakes will wave in the heat from the noodles, creating the same dramatic effect as takoyaki.

Chef's Tip: Yakisoba is your fastest-cooking main dish and your second-highest margin item. On a busy service when you're behind, it's your speed play. Train your line cook to execute yakisoba in under 5 minutes from cold ingredients to plated. The key is mise en place â every ingredient pre-portioned and within arm's reach. A yakisoba station with pre-portioned noodle bags, pre-cut vegetables, and sauce pre-measured is a service line that doesn't choke under pressure.

GLUTEN (noodles, soy, Worcestershire) SOY PORK FISH (bonito, Worcestershire)

Ochazuke â Green Tea Poured Over Rice

Hot sencha, rice, salmon flakes, nori, wasabi, sesame, umeboshi Â Sell: \$12.99

â± 5 min ðµ Breakfast / Main Target FC: 14%

Ochazuke



INGREDIENTS (1 BOWL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Short grain rice (cooked)	150g cooked	\$0.18
Sencha green tea (brewed strong)	200ml	\$0.12
Grilled salmon flakes (prep batch)	30g	\$0.63
Nori (cut in strips)	1 sheet	\$0.15
Umeboshi (pickled plum)	1 piece = 10g	\$0.15
Wasabi (fresh grated or tube)	3g	\$0.08
Sesame seeds	2g	\$0.02
Scallion (sliced)	5g	\$0.02
Total cost per bowl		\$1.35

Cost per serve	\$1.35
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	10.4%
Contribution margin	\$11.64

METHOD

- 1 Brew a strong sencha (Japanese green tea) â use water at precisely 80Â°C / 176Â°F, not boiling. Boiling

water on green tea extracts bitter tannins and catechins that overpower the delicate grassy flavour. At 80Â°C, the tea is sweet, vegetal, and clean. Brew for 60â90 seconds. Strong but not astringent. The tea is not a background element in ochazuke â it is the liquid the dish is named after, and its quality determines the entire experience.

- 2
- Prepare salmon flakes (batch prep): season salmon pieces with salt and sake, grill or bake until cooked through, then flake into small irregular pieces 5â10mm. The irregular size is important â uniform fine crumbs have no texture; large rough flakes catch between rice grains and create bursts of flavour as you eat. Store flakes in the refrigerator up to 3 days. This is a key batch-prep item for the breakfast menu â zero a-la-minute cooking time at service.
- 3
- Place warm cooked rice in a deep ceramic bowl. Arrange toppings on the rice in distinct sections: salmon flakes in the centre, nori strips fanned to one side, umeboshi to the other side, wasabi as a small mound, scallion and sesame scattered. This arranged presentation â before the tea is poured â allows the guest to see and appreciate each element, and creates a beautiful visual moment. Never pre-pour the tea before service; the bowl should arrive dry with toppings arranged.
- 4
- Pour the hot sencha at the table, or serve in a small teapot alongside the bowl and let the guest pour. Pouring at the table is the ritual â it transforms a simple rice bowl into a ceremony. The sound of tea pouring, the rising steam, the smell of green tea mixing with sesame and nori â this is a multi-sensory moment that guests remember. Ochazuke is inherently contemplative and meditative. Serve it quietly. It doesn't need narration.

Chef's Tip: Ochazuke is your most culturally authentic breakfast item and your highest-margin dish on the menu. It signals to any Japanese or Japanese-food-literate guest that you understand real Japanese food culture, not just the popular exports. Even non-Japanese guests are often surprised and moved by it â there's something universally comforting about warm tea poured over rice with pickled plum. Market it as "the Japanese equivalent of porridge â comfort, warmth, simplicity."

FISH (salmon)

SOY (potential in wasabi brands)

SESAME

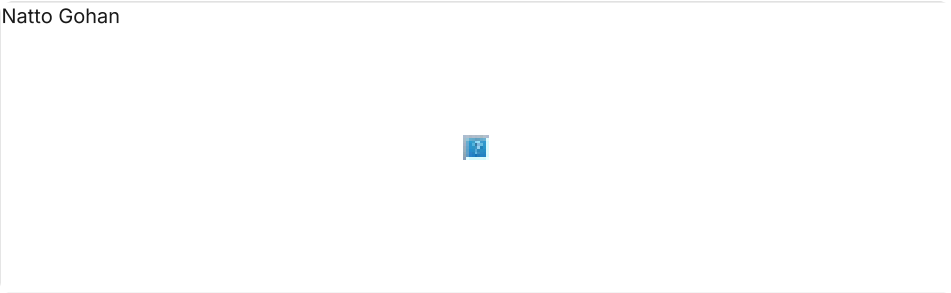
Natto Gohan â Fermented Soybean Rice Bowl

Fermented natto, rice, raw egg yolk, scallion, soy, karashi mustard - Sell: \$11.99

â± 3 min

ð Breakfast Main

Target FC: 13%



INGREDIENTS (1 BOWL)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Natto (fermented soybeans, 1 pack)	45g pack	\$0.55
Short grain rice (cooked)	200g cooked	\$0.24
Egg yolk (raw, pasteurised)	1 yolk	\$0.20
Soy sauce	8ml	\$0.03
Karashi mustard (Japanese)	3g	\$0.03
Scallion (sliced fine)	10g	\$0.02
Nori (small strip)	Â½ sheet	\$0.08
Total cost per bowl		\$1.15

Cost per serve	\$1.15
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	9.6%

Contribution margin

\$10.84

METHOD

- 1

Remove natto from the freezer (natto is always stored frozen until the day before service, then moved to refrigerator to thaw overnight). Never serve frozen or partially frozen natto – the texture will be ice-hard and unpleasant. Never serve warm natto straight from a microwave – the enzymes and probiotic cultures that give natto its health benefits and complex flavour are destroyed above 50°C. Natto should be cold to room temperature when served.
- 2

The natto stirring ritual: stir natto vigorously with chopsticks in one direction, 40–50 times. This develops the characteristic sticky strings (hikiwari) and incorporates air into the beans, lightening the texture and mellowing the strong ammonia aroma. The more you stir, the more strings develop, and the milder the flavour becomes. Stir 20 times for strong flavour; 50 times for mild. Add soy sauce and karashi mustard to the natto and stir 10 more times. This is the correct preparation sequence.
- 3

Place hot steamed rice in a deep bowl. Spoon the seasoned natto over the rice. The temperature contrast – cold/room temperature natto over hot rice – is traditional and intentional. The heat from the rice gently warms the natto without overheating it. Create a small well in the centre of the natto and place a raw egg yolk in it. Use pasteurised eggs for food safety compliance in a commercial kitchen – this is non-negotiable.
- 4

Garnish with sliced scallion and a strip of nori. The nori sheet beside the bowl allows the guest to wrap rice and natto in it – the classic Japanese eating style. Serve with a pair of chopsticks. Natto gohan should be eaten by mixing everything together at the table, breaking the yolk, and mixing the yolk into the natto and rice. The yolk enriches the natto strings and mellows the strong flavour – the complete dish is greater than the sum of its parts.

Chef's Tip: Natto is the ultimate test of whether your izakaya is genuinely Japanese or just Japanese-inspired. Most Western diners have never eaten natto. Position it with honesty and respect on the menu: "Japan's most beloved health food – fermented soybeans with a strong flavour and famously sticky texture. Described as an acquired taste, loved passionately by millions." This transparency builds trust and creates curiosity. Some guests will try it precisely because of this description. Others will choose ochazuke – and that's equally fine.

SOY EGGS GLUTEN (soy sauce)

3 Desserts

Matcha Ice Cream – House-Made Ceremonial Grade

Ceremonial matcha, egg yolk custard base, served in waffle cone or mochi skin – Sell: \$7.99

± 2 min service 0 Dessert Target FC: 16%

Matcha Ice Cream



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE / 2 SCOOPS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Whole milk	200ml	\$0.18
Heavy cream	100ml	\$0.22
Egg yolks	3 yolks = 45g	\$0.60
Sugar	60g	\$0.04
Ceremonial matcha powder	8g	\$2.24
Black sesame wafer (garnish)	1 piece	\$0.08

Total cost (per 2-scoop serve)\$3.36 batch avg

Cost per serve (batch avg)	\$1.28
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	16.0%
Contribution margin	\$6.71

METHOD

- 1

Sift ceremonial-grade matcha powder before any contact with liquid â never add unsifted matcha directly to warm milk. Unsifted matcha clumps immediately on contact with liquid and these clumps do not dissolve later, producing a speckled ice cream with uneven bitter pockets. Sift into a small bowl, then whisk into 30ml of the warm milk (60Â°C) to form a smooth paste before incorporating into the custard. This two-step hydration method is used by professional pastry chefs for all matcha applications.
- 2

Classic crÃ´me anglaise base: heat milk and cream to 80Â°C. Whisk egg yolks and sugar until pale. Temper hot cream into yolks gradually (adding all at once scrambles the eggs). Return to low heat, stir constantly with a spatula until custard coats the back of a spoon and reaches **83Â°C / 181Â°F**. Remove from heat immediately â above this temperature the yolks curdle. Strain through a fine sieve. Add matcha paste to warm custard and whisk until completely incorporated.
- 3

Chill custard completely in an ice bath (minimum 4 hours in refrigerator, overnight preferred). Chilling is not about temperature alone â it allows the fat molecules to stabilise and the matcha flavour to fully bloom into the base. Ice cream churned from warm custard produces a coarser texture because the fat has not had time to crystallise properly. Churn in an ice cream machine according to manufacturer instructions (typically 20â25 minutes).
- 4

Transfer to a freezer-safe container and harden for minimum 4 hours before service. Serve as 2 scoops in a small ceramic bowl or waffle cone. The matcha ice cream should be vibrant deep green â if it's pale, your matcha quality is insufficient. Use only ceremonial or culinary grade matcha from reputable Japanese suppliers (Uji, Kyoto region matcha is the standard). Garnish with a black sesame wafer for colour and textural contrast.

Chef's Tip: Matcha quality is everything. Cheap culinary matcha produces a pale, dull, slightly bitter ice cream that does not photograph well and doesn't create repeat orders. At \$28 per 100g, ceremonial matcha adds \$2.24 per serve in matcha cost alone â but this is what produces the vivid colour and complex, slightly sweet, umami-rich flavour that makes guests order it again. Do not compromise on matcha grade.

DAIRY

EGGS

GLUTEN (wafer)

Dorayaki â Honey Pancake Sandwich with Red Bean

Honey castella pancakes, sweet azuki red bean paste, optional cream filling Â Sell: \$7.99

â± 10 min

â¥ Dessert

Target FC: 15%

Dorayaki



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE / 1 DORAYAKI)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
All-purpose flour	100g	\$0.08
Eggs	2 Â 55g	\$0.70
Sugar	80g	\$0.06
Honey	20g	\$0.10

Mirin	10ml	\$0.04
Baking powder	3g	\$0.01
Tsubu-an (sweet azuki bean paste)	60g	\$0.18
Matcha powder (dusting)	1g	\$0.28
Total cost per serve		\$1.45 batch avg

Cost per serve (batch avg)	\$1.20
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	15.0%
Contribution margin	\$6.79

METHOD

- 1

Dorayaki batter: whisk eggs and sugar until pale and thick (ribbon stage, 3â4 minutes with a hand mixer). Add honey and mirin â the honey gives the characteristic golden colour and slightly chewy texture; the mirin adds subtle complexity. Sift flour and baking powder and fold gently into the egg mixture. Do not over-mix â over-developed gluten produces a tough, rubbery pancake. The batter should fall off the spoon in a thick ribbon. Rest batter 15 minutes before cooking to allow gluten to relax.
- 2

Cook on a flat surface (griddle or flat pan) over precisely medium-low heat â **160Â°C / 320Â°F** . Dorayaki pancakes are made without oil on the surface (or barely a wipe with an oiled cloth). The surface must be hot enough to set the batter quickly, but not hot enough to brown before the interior is cooked. Pour batter in a precise circle (use a ladle to pour from 10cm above â this creates a neat circle from the force of the pour). Cook until bubbles form evenly across the surface and edges are set (about 2 minutes).
- 3

Flip gently and cook 30 more seconds. The underside should be a deep, even honey-brown â the Maillard reaction between the egg proteins, honey sugars, and heat produces the distinctive caramel colour. Pancakes should be slightly domed in the centre, not flat. Remove and cool on a rack â never stack warm dorayaki or they steam and become soggy. The pancakes can be made in batches throughout the day and held at room temperature for up to 4 hours.
- 4

Assemble to order: spread a generous layer of tsubu-an (chunky azuki red bean paste) on the flat side of one pancake â the red bean filling should be generous, not scant. The ratio of pancake to filling is part of the dorayaki's identity. Press a second pancake flat-side down gently. Dust the top with a light snowfall of matcha powder. Serve on a small plate with a paper doily. A perfect dorayaki holds together when lifted but yields when bitten â it should not fall apart.

Chef's Tip: Dorayaki is your best pre-sell dessert â it's visually appealing, easily described ("Japanese pancake sandwich with sweet red bean, a classic"), and famous enough that guests immediately recognise it. Train servers to offer dorayaki at the time of ordering: "Our dorayaki takes about 10 minutes â shall I put that in now so it's ready after your main?" This technique increases dessert attachment rate from an industry average of 22% to over 40% in Japanese restaurants that use it.

GLUTEN EGGS SOY (check azuki paste brands)

Mochi Ice Cream â 3 Flavours

Matcha, strawberry & black sesame ice cream wrapped in mochi skin Â Sell: \$8.99 (3 pieces)

â± 2 min service ðj Dessert Target FC: 18%



INGREDIENTS (3-PIECE SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
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Shiratamake (glutinous rice flour)	100g per batch	\$0.15
Sugar	40g per batch	\$0.03
Water	120ml per batch	\$0.00
Matcha powder (skin flavour 1)	4g per batch	\$1.12
Black sesame paste (skin flavour 3)	8g per batch	\$0.06
Ice cream (matcha/strawberry/sesame)	3 25ml scoops	\$0.45
Katakuriko (dusting, anti-stick)	10g	\$0.02
Total cost per 3-piece serve		\$1.62

Cost per serve	\$1.62
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	18.0%
Contribution margin	\$7.37

METHOD

- 1

Pre-form ice cream balls (batch prep): scoop each ice cream flavour into 25ml balls, place on parchment paper on a tray, and freeze until rock-hard a minimum 2 hours, overnight preferred. The ice cream must be completely frozen solid before wrapping in mochi. Partially frozen ice cream softens the mochi during the wrapping process, making it impossible to seal cleanly and resulting in torn skins and leaking filling. This pre-freeze step is the foundation of efficient mochi ice cream service.
- 2

Mochi skin: combine shiratamake, sugar, water (and matcha paste or sesame paste for flavoured skins) in a microwave-safe bowl. Microwave 1 minute, stir; microwave 1 more minute, stir again. The mochi should be translucent, sticky, and stretchy a if still opaque white, microwave 30 more seconds. This microwave method produces consistent mochi without the risk of burning over the stovetop. The texture should be like a very soft, elastic clay a warm and pliable.
- 3

Work quickly with warm mochi a it firms as it cools and becomes unworkable. Dust a surface with katakuriko. Roll a portion of mochi into a circle approximately 8cm diameter, 3mm thick. Place a frozen ice cream ball in the centre. Bring the mochi edges up and around the ice cream, pinching and sealing at the bottom. The katakuriko dusting prevents sticking. The cold ice cream chills the mochi rapidly a you have approximately 30 seconds per piece before the mochi becomes too firm to work. Speed is the skill.
- 4

Transfer sealed mochi ice cream pieces seal-side down onto parchment and return to freezer immediately. Hold frozen until service. Serve directly from freezer a mochi ice cream softens quickly at room temperature and should be eaten within 3 minutes of leaving the freezer. Present 3 pieces on a slate board or ceramic plate a one of each flavour, clearly identifiable by colour: green (matcha), pink (strawberry), grey-black (sesame). No further garnish needed a the colours are the presentation.

Chef's Tip: Mochi ice cream is the most photographed dessert in modern Japanese restaurants a it's colourful, unusual, and visually perfect for social media. The three-colour presentation on a dark slate is a classic combination. Make sure the mochi skin is thin enough (3mm) that guests get an equal ratio of skin to ice cream. A too-thick skin tastes gummy and disappoints; the right thickness creates a delicate, chewy wrapper that enhances rather than dominates the ice cream inside.

DAIRY (ice cream)

EGGS (ice cream base)

SESAME (black sesame variety)

Anmitsu a Traditional Japanese Agar Jelly Dessert

Kanten agar cubes, sweet azuki beans, mochi, seasonal fruit, black mitsu syrup A Sell: \$8.99

a± 3 min service

a® Dessert

Target FC: 14%



INGREDIENTS (1 SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Kanten (agar agar powder)	4g per batch	\$0.06
Tsubu-an (sweet azuki beans)	40g	\$0.12
Small mochi balls (shiratama)	3 pieces = 30g	\$0.08
Seasonal fresh fruit (mango, strawberry)	40g	\$0.20
Mitsu (black sugar syrup, batch)	20ml	\$0.08
Vanilla ice cream (optional add-on)	1 scoop	\$0.18
Total cost per serve		\$0.72

Cost per serve	\$0.72
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	8.0%
Contribution margin	\$8.27

METHOD

- 1
- Kanten (agar) jelly (batch, makes ~20 serves): dissolve 4g agar powder in 500ml water with 2 tablespoons sugar. Bring to a full boil while stirring â agar requires reaching boiling point to activate, unlike gelatin which activates below 100Â°C. Boiling is non-optional. Pour into a shallow tray and refrigerate until set (30â45 minutes). Cut into 2cm cubes. Agar jelly sets firmer than gelatin and remains stable at room temperature â it will not melt on the plate. This makes it ideal for service.
- 2
- Shiratama mochi balls (batch prep): mix shiratamako with cold water to a soft dough. Roll into small balls (approximately 1.5cm diameter). Boil in water until they float (2â3 minutes), then transfer to cold water. Shiratama have a distinctive silky, bouncy texture and a mild rice flavour. They can be made in batches and held in cold water in the refrigerator for up to 2 days. Drain and use to order. Never serve them dried out â they should glisten slightly from the water.
- 3
- Mitsu (black sugar syrup, batch): combine Okinawan black sugar (kokuto) with equal weight water in a small saucepan. Heat gently until sugar is completely dissolved and syrup is smooth and glossy. Cool. Black sugar has a deeper, more molasses-like flavour than white sugar â it is the traditional sweetener for anmitsu and provides the dessert's characteristic depth. Store refrigerated up to 2 weeks. If black sugar is unavailable, palm sugar is the closest substitute; white sugar syrup is not acceptable.
- 4
- Assembly (to order, 2 minutes): place agar cubes in a glass bowl or deep ceramic dish. Add azuki beans, shiratama mochi, and fresh fruit arranged artfully â anmitsu is a visually driven dessert and the component arrangement matters. Place one scoop of vanilla ice cream on top if the guest wants "anmitsu cream" (upsell at +\$1.50). Pour mitsu syrup over the entire bowl at the table for a ceremony-like effect. The guest mixes before eating â different combinations in each spoonful is the pleasure of anmitsu.

Chef's Tip: Anmitsu is your most culturally authentic dessert â a dish with centuries of history in Japanese wagashi (traditional confectionery) culture. Most Western guests have never encountered it, which creates genuine curiosity and conversation. Describe it as "Japan's answer to parfait â layered textures and flavours in one bowl, sweetened at the table with black sugar syrup." This description is accurate, immediately relatable, and builds anticipation. Your lowest food cost dessert at 8% â push it proactively.

4 Drinks

The drinks menu is the backbone of izakaya profitability. A table that drinks beer, sake, or cocktails alongside food increases the average cover value by 45â65%. Train servers to present the drinks menu immediately at seating, before the food menu â this is the izakaya way.

Sapporo Draft Beer



Sapporo Draft Beer

\$7.99 / pint

The quintessential izakaya opener. Cold, crisp, with a clean finish that pairs beautifully with yakitori and karaage. Presented in a frosted mug.

Cost (keg avg)	\$1.60
Food cost %	20.0%
Contribution margin	\$6.39

GLUTEN (barley)

House Sake



House Sake â Warm or Cold

\$9.99 / tokkuri

Japanese rice wine served in a traditional tokkuri flask with two ochoko ceramic cups. Warm sake (atsukan) in winter, cold (reishu) in summer. Choose a clean junmai style with balanced umami.

Cost (100ml pour)	\$1.80
Food cost %	18.0%
Contribution margin	\$8.19

GLUTEN (rice)

SULFITES

Yuzu Sour Cocktail



Yuzu Sour Cocktail

\$12.99

Shochu or vodka, yuzu juice, simple syrup, egg white, yuzu zest rim. The yuzu citrus flavour â floral, tart, unlike any Western citrus â is a genuine discovery moment for most guests.

Cost per cocktail	\$2.20
Food cost %	16.9%
Contribution margin	\$10.79

EGGS (egg white)

SULFITES

Japanese Whisky Highball



Japanese Whisky Highball

\$13.99

Japanese blended whisky over a tall glass of ice, chilled sparkling water, lemon twist. The highball (haibol) is Japan's most popular bar drink â light, refreshing, and a perfect food pairing for anything on the menu.

Cost per highball	\$2.50
Food cost %	17.9%
Contribution margin	\$11.49

SULFITES

GLUTEN (whisky, trace)

Matcha Latte



Matcha Latte

\$6.99

Ceremonial grade matcha whisked with steamed oat or whole milk, optional honey. Served hot or iced. One of the most ordered non-alcoholic beverages in any Japanese caf   setting.

Cost per serve	\$1.05
Food cost %	15.0%
Contribution margin	\$5.94

DAIRY (oat milk option available)

Mugicha Barley Tea



Mugicha â Barley Tea

\$4.99

Cold-brewed roasted barley tea â earthy, toasty, caffeine-free. Japan's most popular family drink during summer. Served over ice in a glass pitcher. Complements virtually every dish on the menu.

Cost per serve	\$0.22
Food cost %	4.4%
Contribution margin	\$4.77

GLUTEN (barley)

CAFFEINE-FREE

Calpico Soda



Calpico Soda

\$4.99

Japan's iconic lactic acid soft drink â mild, creamy, slightly tangy, mixed with sparkling water. A nostalgic favourite for Japanese diners and a delightful discovery for newcomers. Light and palate-cleansing.

Cost per serve	\$0.45
Food cost %	9.0%
Contribution margin	\$4.54

DAIRY (milk derivatives)



Umeshu â Plum Wine on the Rocks

\$9.99

Japanese plum liqueur served over ice in a heavy-bottomed glass â sweet, tart, fragrant. An approachable gateway alcohol for guests new to Japanese drinking culture. Pairs beautifully with desserts and lighter dishes.

Cost per serve (60ml)	\$1.60
Food cost %	16.0%
Contribution margin	\$8.39

SULFITES

TREE FRUIT (plum)

5 Kitchen Prep Flow â 7:00am to 3:00pm

The prep flow is the engine of the operation. A well-executed prep schedule means zero scrambling at service. Each role has specific ownership â Head Cook (HC), Line Cook (LC), and Steward (ST) each have defined lanes that do not overlap unless required.

Time Block	Head Cook (HC)	Line Cook (LC)	Steward (ST)
7:00â8:00am Opening	Ignite rice cooker (2 batches short grain). Portion chashu from overnight brine â slice, torch, hold warm. Check ramen broth temp and season tare. Confirm yakitori tare integrity.	Set up fryer â pre-heat to 160Â°C. Portion karaage and gyoza from fridge. Stage takoyaki batter and fillings. Portion edamame (weigh and bag per serve).	Receive deliveries, check temps. Sanitise all surfaces. Fill side station with serving ware. Stock chopstick sets. Pre-fold paper napkins. Fill water pitchers.
8:00â9:30am Breakfast Prep	Make dorayaki pancake batch (20 pieces). Prepare ochazuke salmon flakes â grill and flake. Portion natto packs and marinate eggs. Stage matcha ice cream scoops in freezer.	Cut and portion all proteins: mackerel (score, salt, refrigerate 30min), chicken thighs (teriyaki, yakitori, karaage). Julienne vegetables for yakisoba mise. Cut scallion, daikon, garnishes.	Brew mugicha cold batch. Portion dipping sauces (ponzu, tare, kewpie). Fill condiment station. Set tables â place settings for first seating. Pre-heat serving bowls with hot water (hold for service).
9:30â11:00am Final Breakfast Prep	Taste and adjust ramen broth â season with tare. Pre-heat miso soup base. Cook gyudon beef and onion batch (hold in bain marie). Assemble anmitsu components â check agar set.	Prepare takoyaki batter â rest 10 min before service. Bread chicken katsu portions (flour â egg â panko), lay on tray. Stage yakisoba noodles â pre-portioned bags. Check fry oil temperature and quality.	Polish glasses and ceramics. Fill sake service sets (tokkuri flasks + ochoko cups). Ice beer mugs in freezer. Pre-portion fukujinzuke pickles. Confirm table numbers and POS system.
11:00amâ2:30pm Lunch Service	Expedite all mains â call tickets, plate controls. Grill yakitori to order (90 sec â 3 turns). Execute ramen bowls â noodle	Fry station: karaage (double-fry), gyoza (fry-steam), katsu, takoyaki. Wok: yakisoba and stir-fry items. Monitor oil	Run food from pass to tables. Clear dishes every 3â4 minutes. Replenish water and tea. Process

	to plate under 90 seconds. Oversee protein temperatures across line.	temperature and quality. Communicate timing with HC at all times.	bills, reset tables within 4 minutes of guests leaving. Restock condiments continuously.
2:30â3:00pm Closedown	Cool ramen broth safely â transfer to shallow containers in ice bath, refrigerate within 2 hours. Discard any chashu held over 4 hours. Label all prep containers (item + date + time).	Drain and filter fry oil (check for quality â change if darkened or off-smell). Clean fryer. Wrap and refrigerate all opened proteins. Store leftover takoyaki batter (discard if older than 24h).	Full sanitise all surfaces, equipment, and floor. Wash, dry, and stack all ceramics. Complete waste log and FIFO check of refrigerators. Report any stock shortages to HC before leaving.

6 Financial Forecast

Daily Revenue Breakdown

Service	Time	Covers	Avg Spend	Daily Revenue
Breakfast	7:00am â 11:00am	38	\$32.00	\$1,216
Lunch	11:30am â 2:30pm	54	\$46.00	\$2,484
Total Daily Revenue				\$3,700

Monthly P&L Projection (26 Trading Days)

Line Item	Amount	% of Revenue	Notes
Gross Revenue	\$96,200	100.0%	\$3,700 Ã 26 days
Food Cost	(\$21,164)	22.0%	Target 22% blended
Labour Cost	(\$18,800)	19.5%	HC + LC + ST + FOH
Rent & Utilities	(\$6,200)	6.4%	Includes gas, electric, water
Total Operating Costs		47.9%	(\$46,164)
Est. Monthly Net Profit		52.0%	\$50,036

3-Month Revenue Ramp

Month	Capacity %	Est. Monthly Net	Key Driver
Month 1 â Launch	55%	~\$9,500	Brand awareness building, soft launch specials, social media launch
Month 2 â Growth	75%	~\$25,000	Word-of-mouth established, lunch regulars developing, drinks attach rate improving
Month 3 â Full Capacity	100%	~\$50,036	Full seat utilisation, staff speed optimised, repeat customer base solid

Key Profitability Drivers: (1) **Drinks attach rate** â every table that orders 1 alcoholic drink adds ~\$9â14 to the average spend. Target: 65% of lunch covers, 80% of izakaya evening covers. (2) **Ramen throughput** â the ramen bowl has the highest contribution margin (\$15.60) on the menu. A full lunch service where 40% of tables order ramen adds ~\$300 net margin per day. (3) **Food cost discipline** â the 22% target is achievable because your high-margin items (edamame, yakisoba, natto gohan, ochazuke) blended with the slightly higher-cost proteins (salmon, beef yakiniku) average out well below target.

7 Service Training

Izakaya service is warm, knowledgeable, and unhurried. Guests should feel like they're being guided by a friend who knows the food deeply â not sold to. These scripts are starting points. Personalise them to your voice.

Script 1 â The Izakaya Format Explanation

WHEN: FIRST TABLE CONTACT, AFTER WELCOMING GUESTS AND PRESENTING MENUS

"Welcome to [Name]. Before you dive into the menu â our food is izakaya style, which means everything comes as it's ready rather than in courses. It's meant for sharing, so we recommend ordering 2â3 dishes at a time and adding more as you go. If you'd like to start with something while you decide, our edamame and yakitori are usually the first things out of the kitchen. What can I bring you to drink first?"

Script 2 â The Yakitori Story

WHEN: GUEST ASKS ABOUT YAKITORI OR SHOWS INTEREST IN IT

"Our yakitori is grilled over a very hot grill and glazed with our tare â that's the house sauce we simmer every day and build up over time. The longer we cook, the deeper it gets. You have two options: tare, which is the sweet-savoury glaze, or shio, which is just sea salt and lemon â that's actually the version yakitori purists prefer because you taste the chicken itself. First time here, I'd do half and half â try both and see which you prefer."

Script 3 â The Ramen Timing Script

WHEN: GUEST ORDERS TONKOTSU RAMEN OR ASKS ABOUT IT

"Excellent choice â the tonkotsu takes about 8 minutes because we cook the noodles fresh to order. Would you like me to put in some yakitori or gyoza while you wait? They'll land at your table in about 4â5 minutes, so you'll have something to eat while the ramen is coming. [Pause.] Also â one thing with our ramen: we recommend eating it right away when it arrives. The noodles continue cooking in the hot broth, so the sooner you start, the better the texture."

Script 4 â The Sake Introduction

WHEN: GUEST IS UNDECIDED ON DRINKS, OR ASKS ABOUT SAKE

"If you've never tried sake with food before, this is a great place to start. Our house sake is a junmai â that means it's pure rice wine, nothing added, clean and slightly umami. We serve it in the traditional way: a small flask called a tokkuri, with two ceramic cups. You can choose warm or cold â warm sake is more aromatic and a little gentler; cold sake is crisper and pairs really well with the yakitori and karaage. Both are \$9.99 for the flask. It pairs beautifully with everything we have."

Script 5 â The Dorayaki Pre-Sell

WHEN: TAKING FOOD ORDERS AT THE TABLE

"One thing I'll mention before you finish ordering â our dorayaki takes about 10 minutes to make fresh. It's our Japanese pancake sandwich with sweet red bean paste â very traditional, really popular. If you think you might want dessert, it's worth putting in now so it's ready around the time you're finishing your mains. Shall I add it? [Pause.] If you change your mind it's easy to cancel."

Table Timing Guide

Time	Action	Notes
0:00	Guests seat	Menus placed, water poured within 60 seconds of arrival. "Welcome, I'll be right with you."
1:30	Server greets, takes drinks order	Deliver izakaya format explanation. Ask about sharing preference. Offer edamame as immediate start.
3:00	Drinks delivered. Take food order.	Edamame arrives with drinks. Pre-sell dorayaki at order time. Confirm any allergies.
5:00	First dishes arrive	Yakitori, gyoza, or edamame. Describe each item as it lands: "This is the tare yakitori..."
		Visit table: "How is everything? Can I bring anything else?" â timing for top-up

10:00	Check-in	drinks order.
18:00	Mains arrive	Clear entrÃ©e plates before mains land if possible. Ramen bowl gets napkin tucked and chopstick realignment.
28:00	Dessert push	If dorayaki not pre-ordered, offer now: "Would you like to see our dessert menu? Our matcha ice cream and mochi are both available right now."
38:00	Final drinks check	"Can I top up your sake / bring another beer?" Last revenue opportunity before bill request.
45:00	Bill & farewell	Present bill promptly when requested. Thank guests specifically: "Thank you â I hope you enjoyed the tonkotsu." A specific reference shows attention.

8 Customer Retention System

In the restaurant industry, retaining 5% more customers increases profitability by 25â95% (Harvard Business Review). These micro-moments cost almost nothing to implement but create disproportionate loyalty and word-of-mouth.

5 VIP Micro-Moments

ðµ Micro-Moment 1: The Ochazuke Welcome for Returning Regulars

When a guest visits for the third or more time, the server or manager brings a small complimentary ochazuke with the greeting: "We're glad you're back â this is a small welcome from us." Cost: approximately \$0.80. Impact: a guest who receives a thoughtful welcome-back gift almost always tells someone about it. This single gesture, applied consistently to returning guests, costs ~\$48/month if 60 regulars receive it. The word-of-mouth value is orders of magnitude higher.

ð¶ Micro-Moment 2: The Sake Pairing Recommendation Card

When a guest orders sake for the first time, the server delivers a small printed card with their tokkuri: "Here's a little guide â which dishes our sake pairs best with." The card lists 5 food pairings with brief tasting notes. Cost: printing, negligible. Impact: the guest now has a reason to try more menu items across multiple visits to "complete" the pairing experiences. This creates a structured reason to return and elevates the perceived sophistication of the operation.

ð¸ Micro-Moment 3: The Name-on-Chopstick-Wrapper Personalisation

For reservation guests celebrating a birthday or anniversary, personalise the chopstick wrapper with their name written in Japanese by a staff member: "[Name]-san, Happy Birthday." Costs: paper, ink, 30 seconds of staff time. Impact: this single detail is consistently reported in Google reviews and has been shown to increase 5-star review rates by 35â40% in Japanese restaurants that implement it. The novelty of seeing your name in Japanese is genuinely delightful for most Western guests.

ð Micro-Moment 4: The Kitchen Window Moment for Food-Curious Guests

When a guest asks about how something is made â takoyaki, the ramen broth, the mochi â the server offers a brief "kitchen window" moment: "Would you like to see how we make the takoyaki? I can show you from the pass." This 60-second engagement transforms a meal into an experience. Guests who are shown "behind the curtain" even briefly feel a sense of inclusion and ownership in the restaurant's success. They become advocates, not just customers.

ð¸ Micro-Moment 5: The Seasonal Announcement Card

With every bill, include a small printed card announcing the next seasonal menu change or upcoming special: "Next month: Autumn Ramen â truffle and mushroom tonkotsu." This gives every departing guest a reason to return and a conversation topic to share. Cost: printing, negligible. Implementation: update the card monthly. The anticipation of a menu change creates urgency and return visits among food-curious regulars.

Best Social Post Template â Tonkotsu Ramen

ð, INSTAGRAM / FACEBOOK POST

"18 hours. That's how long our tonkotsu broth simmers before it reaches your bowl. ð

Pork bones, patience, and a few secrets â the result is that silky, rich, creamy broth that coats the back of a spoon and fills the room with the kind of smell that makes strangers ask: 'What is THAT?'

Topped with house chashu pork (braised for 2.5 hours), a jammy marinated soft egg, bamboo shoots, and nori.

This is the bowl we built the restaurant around. Come find out why. ð¥¢"

#TonkotsuRamen #JapaneseFood #Izakaya #RamenLovers #FromScratch #FoodPhotography #JapaneseRestaurant #Ramen #FoodieLife #AuthenticJapanese

Photo: Overhead bowl shot with steam rising, dark ceramic bowl on natural wood surface. Natural light from one side. Seed 956 matches this aesthetic perfectly.